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# HUMAN MACHINES

Are they man, or machine? Power, extreme!

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Someone recently asked us if running is the best way to get fit. We responded with a counter question: what exactly do you mean by fit? If losing fat and slimming down is your only concern, then running and other forms of high intensity cardio is indeed the fastest way of reaching that goal. This response is invariably followed by, "But I want to gain strength and add muscle too". That's when we explain how this fitness business works with our

Farah and Asafa Powell. Farah looks incredibly skinny, whereas Powell is all jacked up like a bodybuilder. Any exercise, when performed repeatedly, results in the body adapting itself to perform the oft-repeated task. In fact, researchers at Karolinska Institutet in Stockholm confirm that the body undergoes changes at the DNA level when subjected to exercise.

That explains Powell's buffness, because explosive sprinting required by 100m running events have conditioned his fast-twitch muscles to deliver explosive strength, which in turn is associated with muscle hypertrophy or increase in

you fancy. An exercise plan focusing on running is a terrible idea if you want to add muscle mass, whereas only lifting heavy weights won't help you slim down in an efficient manner either. However, in establishing this fact, it's pretty evident how rarefied the diversity in skill, morphology, and general athletic efficiency is, at least when it comes to the top tier of sportsmen. The question worth asking here is 'has modern sports pushed the envelope of human anatomical achievement to the very limits?', or more importantly, 'have sportsmen stretched themselves to that point where they are no different from machines?'



The type of exercise performed determines the body type

favourite example: the Olympics. This international sporting event is the very epitome of human potential. And we don't say this as some pithy quotable quote, we really mean it.

The athletes that participate in their respective routines achieve a level of perfection that makes them, quite literally, the very best in the world at that given sport. This is reflected in the way their body types. For example, consider the physical appearances of champion runners Mo

muscle mass. On the other hand, Farah's body is geared towards efficiency. Muscle has high density and is hence heavy, which is exactly why you don't see much of that in Farah's body type. Since strength isn't a factor in long distance endurance events, the body belonging to a runner of that discipline sheds all but the bare minimum level of muscle for maximum lightness and efficiency.

In short – perform exercises according to your fitness goals and not just the ones

## White men can't jump

This is a field where success isn't just a product of hard work but it is largely predetermined by race. For example, the morphological makeup of caucasian and black men have inherent differences when it comes to composition of fast and slow twitch muscle fibres. That's why white men generally excel in traditional strongman events focusing on feats of brute strength, whereas black men dominate the track and field events in the Olympics. Well known neurologist and Oxford Dean, Sir Roger Bannister, faced a lot of flak for his controversial statements about black athletes having a natural anatomical advantage, especially in track and field routines.

Although contentious, Bannister's claim are rooted deeply in reality. For example, 95 per cent of the world records in sprint are held by black people of West